

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

CHICAGO CITY COUNCIL

Mayor delays budget vote

Facing imminent defeat, Johnson will now try to reach spending plan deal with aldermen before Monday

Property tax increase, refusal to cut spending remain roadblocks in unprecedented government stalemate

\$68.5M

After backing down from an initial \$300 million property tax increase, Mayor Brandon Johnson's Friday proposal maintained a more modest \$68.5 million hike on taxes. Even progressive allies have balked at that idea, instead seeing an opening to achieve a longstanding goal of cutting police spending.

By Alice Yin and A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson made an eleventh-hour decision to cancel a Friday vote on his 2025 budget plan, the latest setback for the mayor after months of squabbling with aldermen and failing to shore up enough support in the City Council to finalize a \$17.3 billion fiscal package that still

contains a property tax hike and minimal cuts.

The mayor's handpicked Budget Committee chair, West Side Ald. Jason Ervin, moved to recess the morning council meeting until 1 p.m. Monday. Between now and then, Johnson must tweak the proposal and strong-arm or cajole enough holdout aldermen to fall in line while battling growing doubts over his leadership abilities.

In a post-council news conference, Johnson told reporters, "The reality is, we're very close, but we're still not there yet."

"We have been in very fruitful conversations," Johnson said. "We're not going to stop doing that. I am still very optimistic that we will pass a balanced budget before the end of the year that keeps our city up and running and does not cut vital city services."

The Tribune reported earlier Friday morning that Johnson's intergovernmental affairs team called aldermen late Thursday to tell them the mayor would not try to pass his spending plan Friday after all.

Ervin's motion came as no surprise but nonetheless sparked a brief parliamentary spat, with

Turn to Budget, Page 2



Downers Grove residents show support for Commissioner Leslie Sadowski-Fugitt as she speaks about a proposed nonbinding referendum on the village's public library during a Village Council meeting on Dec. 3. CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

In suburb, old rift resurfaces

Downers Grove considers elected library board, possibly reopening village's culture war wounds

By Caroline Kubzansky
Chicago Tribune

A west suburban library that became a battleground for national culture wars is on the defensive again. Two years after the Downers Grove library was forced to cancel

a planned drag queen bingo over right-wing threats, leaders of the western suburb are considering a controversial proposal to replace the appointed members of the library board with an elected one. "This will tear our community apart for no reason," warned resident Debbie Anderson Phillips

at a recent emotionally charged library board meeting. "It will be an ugly, ugly, ugly fight."

Changing the library board is still just a flicker of an idea. But the agitation it has created is perhaps the product of the past seven years in which the six-member library board has endured the removal of two trustees and sustained pressure from local conservatives over LGBTQ+-related programming and materials. That history

has some residents worried that a library election would attract outside interest groups seeking to influence local politics.

Mayor Bob Barnett — who has supported the institution's staff and its programming in the face of previous attacks — is one of the Village Council members backing the pitch, which the village must table or place on the ballot

Turn to Library, Page 4

Pritzker takes aim at hemp products

Governor calls out delta-8 'loophole' as shops fight back

By Robert McCoppin and Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

Gov. JB Pritzker is calling on lawmakers to crack down on hemp products like delta-8 THC, saying they let minors get high on untested, mislabeled cannabis — but it's a move hemp shop owners say would also close legitimate businesses.

The governor came out Friday in support of legislation that would set a minimum age of 21 to buy such products. It would require hemp companies to obtain licenses and test and label their products, similar to the requirements for legal marijuana. And it would ban copycat packaging that looks like common candy or snack brands.

"This regulatory gray area has created a loophole that put Illinois consumers of all ages, but particularly children, in danger while an underground market flourished — the exact opposite of what Illinois has done by regulating our cannabis industry," Pritzker said. "We're closing that loophole and protecting Illinoisans of all ages by incorporating these

Turn to Hemp, Page 4

Suspect praised operation before withdrawing socially

By Lea Skene and Jennifer Sinco Kelleher
Associated Press

After Luigi Mangione made the difficult decision to undergo spinal surgery last year for chronic back pain, he became a proponent of the procedure that changed his life for the better.

He repeatedly posted on Reddit about his recovery and offered words of encouragement for people with similar conditions, telling them to push back against doctors who suggested they had to live with pain.

But notably absent from the

posts are explicit concerns about corporate greed in the health insurance industry. Those appear to have surfaced only later: in a handwritten note found after Mangione was detained as a suspect in the killing of UnitedHealthcare CEO Brian Thompson.

That short document references "parasites" in the health care system and laments the power and profits of health insurers, according to law enforcement officials. During his first public words since his arrest

Turn to Suspect, Page 6



TESS CROWLEY/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

New citizens take oath of allegiance

Jagath Muthuswamy, 9, inspects his grandmother Mohana Krishnaswamy's certificate of naturalization with his grandfather Jagatheesan Muthuswamy after both grandparents signed their certificates at a ceremony at the Griffin Museum of Science and Industry in Chicago on Friday. Nearly 150 people were set to become U.S. citizens.

Cubs deal for middle-of-the-order bat

The Cubs landed a power hitter for their lineup, acquiring outfielder Kyle Tucker from the Astros for infielder Isaac Paredes, pitcher Hayden Wesneski and their 2024 first-round pick, Cam Smith. **Chicago Sports**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 38 Low 36

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 8

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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